

the root cause is the best way to solve any problem.

Generate as many ideas as possible before you begin to judge them.

Here is a catch, though. To produce enough meaningful and clever ideas, you need creativity. But additionally, you also need experience. Without enough experience you cannot produce enough innovative ideas.

However, there is an antidote. It is to collaborate with other experts in various relevant domains and combine their knowledge with your creativity. When time is of essence, this is the best way to move forward.

Another way to circumvent the limitation of experience is experimentation. Many people mistake experimentation with trial and error. It is not so. Experimentation is an art. And it is also science. Experimentation teaches you so many things in a brief period that otherwise will take several years to learn.

Based on your experimental findings, and observations, etc, you can generate as many ideas as possible. But do not judge them at this stage yet.

Get analytical

We all can agree that every idea is not and cannot be equally good. Some ideas are outright pointless. Some ideas are good but may not be feasible or viable from a business standpoint. Sometimes, an idea is good but the timing is not right for it.

So, the third step is to apply critical thinking and analyse all your ideas for their usefulness, feasibility, and relevance. Pick the most suitable one that makes more sense at the current stage. Also, consider whether you can develop it further reasonably, if needed.

Shaping it beyond just an idea

Picking one idea is just the beginning. It needs to be developed and shaped up further to commercialise and implement

it at scale. This is where the fourth step of validation comes into play.

In most cases, it is unlikely that you will validate your idea all by yourself. You will need help. You will have to collaborate with multiple people and experts to ensure your idea improves and becomes more robust.

During my time with Knewron, I came across hundreds of fantastic ideas. Only a handful of them were scalable or implementable. Often, people who had those ideas knew what they wanted and what they were doing.

“Apply critical thinking and analyse your ideas for their usefulness, feasibility, viability, and relevance.”

Firsthand experience is underrated these days but having it or not having it shows up vividly at this stage. This means the key is to get people with good and diverse experiences involved early in the process. This can save you time and money eventually.

Validate your chosen idea and develop it further for all practical purposes.

It can go nowhere without communication

You might think that after the development, production and distribution are logical steps. But before that there is another crucial step. In fact, it is one of those steps which make people cringe

and ask road-blocking questions, like “Why are we doing this?”

No matter how good your idea or the solution is, you need to sell it. Not just to the customers but all the stakeholders involved in the supply chain and the process. Without their help and buy-in, the implementation, production, processing, and delivery will stifle.

Communication is not just about selling. It is also about articulating your idea. How and why you developed it. How your solution fits in your customers’ lives. It helps you to make sure that more people can understand it and benefit from it.

What is the point of innovation if others cannot understand it, right?

Communicate your work. Articulate the problem, its root cause, and how the idea you developed solves it.

The point is

Innovation requires more than just a bunch of ideas or creativity. It needs discipline. It needs a process to follow.

If you are implementing innovation programmes in your organisation, or want to be more innovative, or simply want to streamline things, this is where you can start. Establishing a high-level process that people can understand and follow is the key to their participation. A mere suggestion box or idea competition will not take you anywhere. It is an old-school approach.

‘Being innovative’ means you need to think forward and find new ways of doing things, for your own and for your people’s sake. Now is the time to find some problems to solve, follow the process, and make your ideas a reality **END** 🐧

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